

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

There are truths
about our future
actions.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

We started off with two arguments for the reality of fate.

We have no
choice about the
past.

Let's turn to our last line of response to the two arguments. This is to deny the assumption, common to both arguments, that we have no choice about the past.

The denial of this assumption is often associated with William of Ockham, an English philosopher and theologian who was born about 15 years after Aquinas' death, in 1288. (He's the one that "Ockham's razor" is named after.)



To see why this might not be ridiculous, consider the overlooked philosophical problem of the incompatibility of free will and roommate true belief.

It seems that sometimes, your roommate can have true beliefs about what you will do; for example, the following might be true:

At 10 am today, your roommate
believed that you would eat a salad
for lunch.

Now imagine that at noon you are in the dining hall, about to grab a salad, when you are suddenly overcome with an unlikely desire for a fish sandwich. Do you have a choice about whether you will choose the salad or the fish sandwich? It seems that you do. **But then it also seems that you have a choice about whether your roommate's belief, at 10 am, was true.** After all, if you had chosen the fish sandwich, your roommate's belief that you would eat a salad will have been false.

If this story makes sense, it follows that you do sometimes have a choice about past facts: you had a choice about whether, in the past, a certain belief about your future actions was true.

Of course, this does not mean that you have a choice about **every** past fact. For example, you don't now have a choice about whether you wore a blue shirt yesterday. But consider the sorts of "past facts" at play in the Fatalist Argument.

They are facts like this:

In 2000 BC it was true that on
6/1/2030 you will get married.

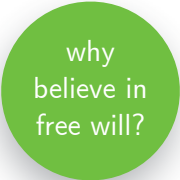
This is a fact about the past; but it is also partly about the future. It is perhaps not so hard to believe that you will have a choice in 2030 about whether in 2000 BC this was a fact.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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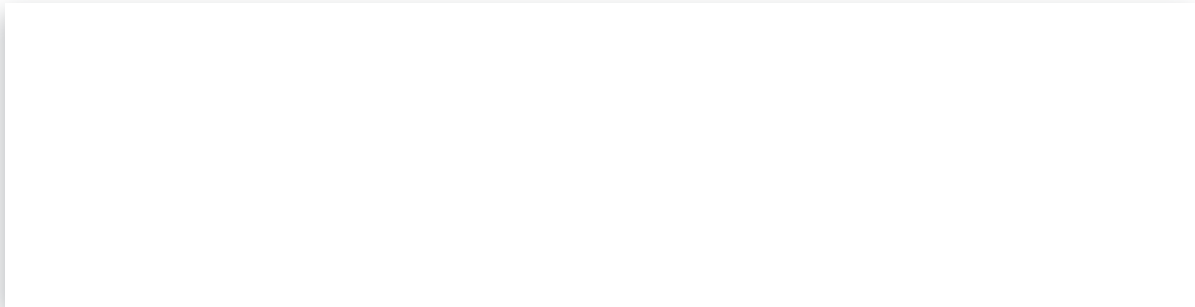
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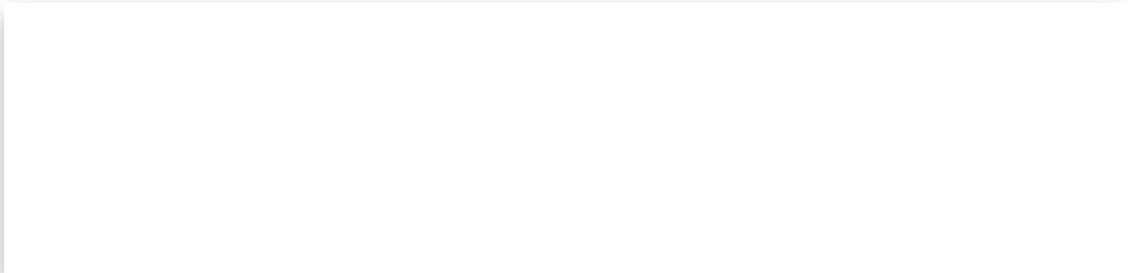
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So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

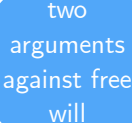
and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

things as fate, then there is no free will.

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

similar to Edwards' argument?

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

Suppose that someone did not believe in

there were truths about all our future

actions. Could they give an argument

God only shows up in premises (2) and

with reference to the being of truth about

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

our future actions.



(3, 4, 5)

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

1. We have no direct facts.

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

God knows that in the future I will

5* We have noticed that the fact

2* In the past, there were truths about

0 We have achieved what we

perform a certain action (1,2)



some action, then I will prefer that

3 We have not the fact that

then we have the choice about q.

that if it is true that I will perform

all of our activities.

acaioid.

will perform various actions.

The fatalist argument

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Fatalist Argument.

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now have a choice about whether it rained yesterday.

choice about every past fact. For example, you don't



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